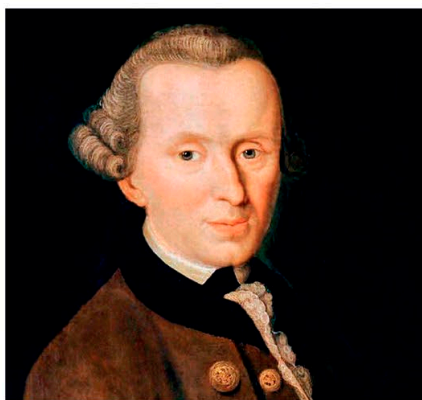


1700-1789

THE ENLIGHTENMENT

A broad philosophical and cultural movement, the Enlightenment dominated intellectual and artistic endeavour in Europe and North America in the 18th century. It was rooted in the Scientific Revolution and the works of political theorists such as John Locke – who believed that men are free and equal by nature – and touched on many areas of life including politics, religion, and economics. Enlightenment thinkers championed rationality and freedom of thought over the “darkness” of dogma, faith, and superstition. For theorists such as Voltaire, Jean-Jacques Rousseau, Immanuel Kant, and Thomas Paine, reason was the primary source of authority and legitimacy. They

explored ideas of liberty, equality, progress, tolerance, and constitutional government, challenging the power of Europe’s monarchies and the Church and driving the revolutions of the 18th century. Paine and Rousseau argued against absolutist monarchy and the divine right to rule and so influenced the French Revolution and American Declaration of Independence. Yet for all the emphasis on equality and freedom, such concepts were often only selectively applied. Equality came slowly to include women and people of colour; indeed, the Enlightenment’s scientific approach helped establish a pseudo-scientific basis for racism that was used to justify slavery and colonial oppression.



KEY MOMENTS

1763 Diderot publishes his *Encyclopédie*

French philosopher Denis Diderot’s *Encyclopédie, ou dictionnaire raisonné des sciences, des arts et des métiers* (sample page shown left) attempted to catalogue all human knowledge in science, philosophy, politics, and religion. Its assertion that the government’s main concern should be the common people provided the rationale for the French Revolution.

1784 Kant’s “What is Enlightenment?” defines the movement

In this 1784 essay, German philosopher Immanuel Kant (left) defined enlightenment as “man’s emergence from self-incurred immaturity”. He suggested that people found it difficult to throw off this immaturity, and easier to accept the status quo, because they lacked the courage to think for themselves. The cultivation of the mind, which Kant summarized with the motto “Dare to be wise”, was key to Enlightenment thinking.

